

Changing narratives, from icons to surfaces

Our correspondents capture **the essence of IPL's** Chennai and Lucknow legs — thrilling action on the field and captivating stories beyond it.

By the time M.S. Dhoni found the gap behind point and struck the first boundary of his innings in the final over of the chase against Delhi Capitals, there was a hush around the M.A. Chidambaram Stadium. That four left Chennai Super Kings needing an impossible 28 runs off two balls.

The Chennai crowd, which would throw itself into a frenzy at the very sight of the talisman on the giant screen, had watched the 43-year-old rage against age and conditions for 43 minutes during an unfruitful 84-run partnership with Vijay Shankar. The cheers had petered out,

and the odd blow of the whistle was perhaps a portent of the shifting dynamics of sports fandom in the Indian Premier League (IPL).

At 18, had the IPL finally matured and shed itself of the scourge of 'the cult of personality'? Had the collective finally triumphed over the individual?

This was Super Kings' third defeat on the bounce and their second consecutive loss at home against teams they had not lost to at the venue in 15 years. Something had to give, and on that evening, perhaps an element of that unyielding hero worship did.

While there was criticism of Dhoni's entry points in the last two



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